

The End of Loyalty



Cricket loves its flaps and the latest flap was New South Wales's (NSW) signing of New Zealander Brendon McCullum to play in Australia's national T20 final, the elegantly named KFC Big Bash. State teams can contract one overseas player for the Big Bash and this season Pakistanis Umar Gul and Sohail Tanvir had played for Aussie state teams. McCullum though signed on for a single game persuaded only by the Twenty20 Champions League. NSW can now bank on the marvellous McCullum in case NSW's stars are obliged to turn out for their Indian Premier League (IPL) teams in the Champions League. In turn, McCullum can bank on a crack at the League's US \$5m prize even if his IPL team, the Kolkata Knight Riders, don't qualify.

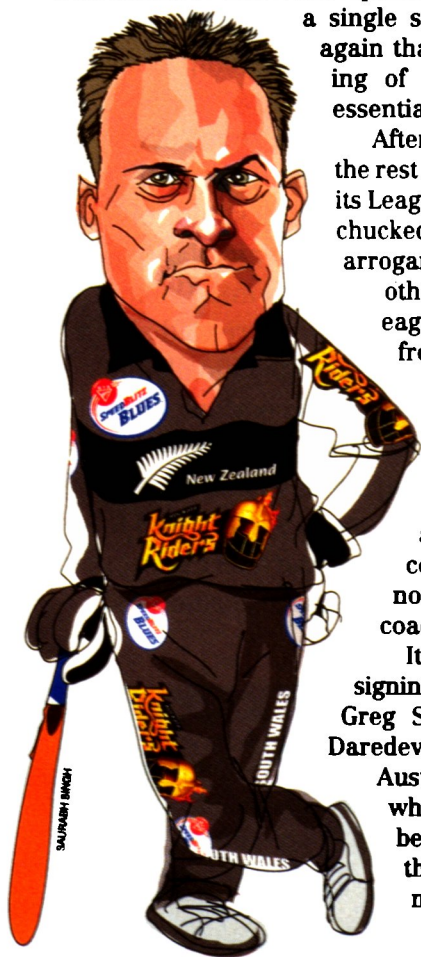
For all this to happen, McCullum's provincial team in New Zealand had to let him miss an important one-day game, which they did and his board had no objections either. So NSW, going against convention, signed their first overseas player since 1984-85. For one game. The incident may not have marked the end of civilisation, but it has signalled an end of loyalty as previously, and provincially, understood. Outsider 'pros' traditionally adopt their team's cause over a long term and not act merely as short-term band-aid. Not so any more. McCullum did donate his NZ \$6,000 NSW match fee to youth cricket in his home province of Otago, but the 'hired gun signing' has left many very uncomfortable. It is clear now that difference between 'Mumbai' and 'Mumbai Indians' is not one of nomenclature alone, but of philosophy and orientation. It has taken a single six-week IPL season to prove yet again that the contemporary understanding of the word 'values' tends to be essentially financial.

After McCullum-like events, the rage of the rest of the world ends up directed, inevitably, at India and its League. Words like "fistful of rupees" are contemptuously chucked about, unmindful of the wee fact that inefficient, arrogant, bully-boy India may be dishing out the cash, but others are doing the taking with an almost embarrassing eagerness. Executives on IPL teams say cricket agents from overseas beat down their doors every single day. Just making a living? Well, then that should hold good for Poms, Kiwis, Aussies, Lankans, West Indians—and Indians.

In this pursuit of livelihood the IPL has become such a lovefest, it's like Woodstock revisited. CEOs and coaches recommend friends as assistant coaches or assistants to assistants. IPL coaches nominate—and hire—players from the teams they coach back at home.

It must be pure coincidence that Delhi Daredevil's new signings mostly come from Victoria, the state coached by Greg Shipperd, who in his free time works with the Daredevils. Kings XI Punjab's rookies are from Western Australia, where Tom Moody coaches when he's not whipping Preity Zinta's boys into shape. Now, this could be a function of familiarity. Or equally, of favouritism. In the IPL bubble, where notions like conflict of interest do not exist, there's just no telling.

IN ITS PURSUIT OF LIVELIHOOD, THE IPL HAS BECOME A LOVEFEST LIKE WOODSTOCK REVISITED.



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Ramaswamy Venkataraman, 98, the eighth president of India from July 25, 1987 till July 25, 1992. Earlier, he was Union

SHARAD SAXENA



minister for defence and finance. He was also deputy chairman of the Planning Commission and a member of the Constituent Assembly that drafted the Constitution.

APPOINTED: K.C. Verma, internal security adviser to Home Minister P. Chidambaram, as the chief of the external intelligence agency Research & Analysis Wing (RAW).

DIED: Ram Babu Sharma, 53, Congress legislator from northeast Delhi's Rohtas Nagar and former chief of Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee.



WON: By Badrinath Chopra, 86, gold medals in the 800 m hurdles and 5,000 m walk at the Asian Masters Athletics Championships in Chiang Mai, Thailand. His wife Krishna, 82, won three golds in 400 m and 200 m races and 5,000 m walk.